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Addition tricks — Numbers 34 to 44

Each passage is now a mini-lesson: a challenge to hook them in, the trick, one worked example, two for the child to try, then both checked together — with encouragement all the way through. Read it like you're at the kitchen table and someone just asked "go on then, show me".

The four rules

1. Before each passage say its number clearly — "Number one", "Number two" — pause a second, read the passage, then pause a couple of seconds before the next number. Those gaps are how I find the joins. 2. Wherever you see ... leave a short beat — two seconds is plenty. Those are the "have a think" moments for the kids. 3. If you stumble, don't stop the recording: pause, say the SAME number again, and read that passage again. I'll keep your retake. 4. Kitchen-table warmth beats newsreader polish every time.

Total is roughly two hours of reading — absolutely fine to do over several sittings (each take just needs to start at a numbered item; tick them off on the printed version as you go). When done, drop the audio file(s) — m4a, mp3, wav, anything — into OneDrive Times tables/recordings and tell me.

Tick each number as you record it so you can pick up where you left off.

Part B — Addition tricks

■ Say: "Number 34" — Left to Right

Quick one to warm up — what's 34 plus 52? ... If you had it before I finished asking, superb. If not, don't panic — this trick sorts it in two easy moves. It's called Left to Right, and it means adding the biggest parts first. Split each number into tens and ones, add the tens, add the ones, then put the two answers together. Watch 34 plus 52. The tens first: 30 plus 50 is 80. Now the ones: 4 plus 2 is 6. Put them together: 80 plus 6 is 86. So 34 plus 52 is 86. Always start with the tens — that's the big chunk of the answer done straight away. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 45 plus 23? ... and what's 61 plus 36? ... Have a proper go before I tell you... Let's check them. 45 plus 23: tens first, 40 plus 20 is 60. Ones next, 5 plus 3 is 8. Together: 60 plus 8 is 68. And 61 plus 36: 60 plus 30 is 90, then 1 plus 6 is 7, and 90 plus 7 is 97. See? Big bits first and the sum falls open — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 35" — Number Bonds

Lightning round — what goes with 7 to make 10? ... If you said 3 before you could blink, you already know today's trick. If you had to count on your fingers — perfect, let's fix that right now. Number bonds are the pairs that make 10: 7 plus 3, 6 plus 4, 8 plus 2, 5 plus 5. The trick is simple — learn them off by heart so you never have to count them out. And here's the bonus: they work for 100 too. 70 plus 30, 60 plus 40, 80 plus 20 — the same pairs, just ten times bigger. So for our opener: 7 plus 3 is 10 — the missing partner was 3, instantly, no counting. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what goes with 6 to make 10? ... and 70 plus what makes 100? ... Say them out loud before I do... Checking time. 6 needs its partner 4, because 6 plus 4 is 10. And 70 needs 30, because 70 plus 30 is 100 — that's just the bond 7 plus 3 wearing a bigger coat. Knowing your bonds makes every other trick in this game faster. That's it — you've got the building blocks now. Go play.

■ Say: "Number 36" — Bigger Number First

Quick one — what's 3 plus 28? ... If you got 31 in a couple of seconds, nice work. If you started counting up from 3 — ooh, stop right there, because this trick will save you loads of effort. Here's the secret: adding is easier if you start with the bigger number. Flipping the sum round changes nothing about the answer — 3 plus 28 is exactly the same as 28 plus 3. So don't slog up from 3. Start at 28 and count on just three little hops: 29, 30, 31. So 3 plus 28 is 31. Done in a breath. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 2 plus 47? ... and what's 4 plus 65? ... Have a proper go before I check... Right then. 2 plus 47: flip it to 47 plus 2, count on — 48, 49. So 2 plus 47 is 49. And 4 plus 65: flip it to 65 plus 4, count on — 66, 67, 68, 69. So 4 plus 65 is 69. Big number first, tiny hops after. See? You've got this one — go race through the practice.

■ Say: "Number 37" — Count On

Quick one — what's 46 plus 3? ... If that popped out in a couple of seconds, you're already doing this trick without knowing it. If not, no bother at all — it takes about a minute to learn. Here it is: when you're adding 1, 2 or 3, don't work anything out. Just count up from the big number, one little hop at a time. A few hops and you're done. So for 46 plus 3, start at 46 and hop: 47 ... 48 ... 49. Three hops, and you land on 49. So 46 plus 3 is 49. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 65 plus 2? ... and what's 88 plus 3? ... Have a proper go before I tell you ... Right, let's check together. 65 plus 2: start at 65 and hop twice — 66 ... 67. So 65 plus 2 is 67. Now 88 plus 3: start at 88 — 89 ... 90 ... 91. So 88 plus 3 is 91. See how it hops straight over the 90 without a wobble? That's it — you now know a trick you'll use every single day.

■ Say: "Number 38" — Doubles

Quick one — what's 7 plus 7? ... If you said 14 before I finished asking, brilliant — you already know this one. If you had to count it out, stick with me, because this trick is all about never counting again. A double is just a number added to itself, and the secret is simple: learn them off by heart, so they're instant. Doubles are the anchors that loads of other sums lean on. Let's walk the family: 6 plus 6 is 12. 7 plus 7 is 14. So our hook question, 7 plus 7 — no working out, no fingers — it's just 14, straight from memory. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 8 plus 8? ... and what's 9 plus 9? ... Say them out loud before I do ... Ready? 8 plus 8 is 16 — that's 8 added to itself, 16, every time. And 9 plus 9 is 18 — again, no counting, just 18. Say them once more: 16 ... 18. Lovely. The more you say them, the faster they get, until they're as automatic as your own name. See? You've got this one — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 39" — Near Doubles

Quick one — what's 6 plus 7? ... Got it in under ten seconds? Then you're halfway to mastering this already. If not, don't worry a bit — this trick makes it easy. A near double is a sum that's almost a double. So spot the double hiding inside, double the smaller number, then add the extra 1. Let's do 6 plus 7 properly. It's nearly 6 plus 6. Double the 6 to get 12, then add the extra 1 to get 13. So 6 plus 7 is 13. And here's a bonus tip: if the two numbers are 2 apart, just double the middle one. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 8 plus 9? ... and what's 7 plus 9? ... Have a proper think before I say ... Let's check together. 8 plus 9: that's nearly 8 plus 8. Double 8 is 16, add the extra 1 — 17. So 8 plus 9 is 17. Now 7 plus 9: those are 2 apart, so double the middle number, which is 8. Double 8 is 16. So 7 plus 9 is 16. That's it — you now know a trick most grown-ups don't.

■ Say: "Number 40" — Make Ten

Quick one — what's 8 plus 5? ... If that came out in a flash, you already know this one. If it didn't, brilliant — you're about to learn my favourite adding trick. It's called Make Ten. Instead of adding straight across, you jump to the next ten first, because tens are easy. Ask how much gets you to 10, split the second number to match, and finish the job. Watch with 8 plus 5. How many gets 8 up to 10? That's 2. So split the 5 into 2 and 3. Now 8 plus 2 is 10, and 10 plus 3 is 13. So 8 plus 5 is 13. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 7 plus 8? ... and what's 9 plus 8? ... Have a proper go before I tell you ... Let's check them together. 7 plus 8: 7 needs 3 to make 10, so split the 8 into 3 and 5. 7 plus 3 is 10, then 10 plus 5 is 15. And 9 plus 8: 9 only needs 1, so split the 8 into 1 and 7. 9 plus 1 is 10, then 10 plus 7 is 17. See? You've got this one — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 41" — Spot the Tens

Quick one — what's 6 plus 3 plus 4 plus 7? ... If you rattled that off in under ten seconds, you might already be using this trick. If not, no worries — it's a lovely one. When you're adding a whole string of numbers, don't plod through in order. Scan the line and spot the pairs that make 10 first, because tens are the easiest things in the world to add. Let's do our hook question. In 6 plus 3 plus 4 plus 7, spot the pairs: 6 plus 4 is 10, and 3 plus 7 is 10. Now just add the tens: 10 plus 10 is 20. So 6 plus 3 plus 4 plus 7 is 20. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 8 plus 5 plus 2 plus 5? ... and what's 5 plus 9 plus 5? ... Hunt for those pairs before I tell you ... Let's check together. 8 plus 5 plus 2 plus 5: the 8 and the 2 make 10, and 5 plus 5 makes 10 — so 10 plus 10 is 20. And 5 plus 9 plus 5: pair the 5 and 5 for 10, then 10 plus 9 is 19. See? Once you spot the tens, long sums fall apart — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 42" — Round and Adjust

Quick one — what's 38 plus 27? ... If you got that in under ten seconds, hats off — you already think like this. If not, no worries at all, because this trick makes messy sums tidy. It's called Round and Adjust. Round one number up to something tidy, do the easy sum, then fix it afterwards by taking back what you borrowed. Watch with 38 plus 27. Round 38 up to 40 — that's 2 extra. Now the easy sum: 40 plus 27 is 67. Take back the 2 you added: 67 minus 2 is 65. So 38 plus 27 is 65. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 49 plus 24? ... and what's 68 plus 15? ... Have a proper go before I tell you ... Let's check together. 49 plus 24: round 49 up to 50 — that's 1 extra. 50 plus 24 is 74, then take back the 1: 74 minus 1 is 73. And 68 plus 15: round 68 up to 70 — that's 2 extra. 70 plus 15 is 85, take back the 2: 85 minus 2 is 83. That's it — you now know a trick most grown-ups don't.

■ Say: "Number 43" — Give and Take

Quick one — what's 47 plus 26? ... Under ten seconds? Then this trick is already living in your head. If not, perfect — let's put it there now. It's called Give and Take, and the idea is lovely: you can give a bit from one number to the other, and the total stays exactly the same. Give just enough to make one number a nice round ten. Watch with 47 plus 26. Give 3 from the 26 across to the 47. The 47 becomes 50, and the 26 becomes 23. Now it's easy: 50 plus 23 is 73. So 47 plus 26 is 73. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 58 plus 34? ... and what's 29 plus 45? ... Have a proper go before I tell you ... Right, let's check together. 58 plus 34: give 2 from the 34 to the 58. That makes 60 plus 32, which is 92. So 58 plus 34 is 92. And 29 plus 45: give 1 from the 45 to the 29. That makes 30 plus 44, which is 74. So 29 plus 45 is 74. See? You've got this one — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 44" — Add 9 and 99

Quick one — what's 56 plus 9? ... If you got that in under ten seconds, you already know this one. If not — no worries at all, let's learn it right now. Adding 9 is sneaky-easy, because 9 is nearly 10. So don't add 9 at all: add 10, which is dead easy, then take 1 back. Watch with 56 plus 9. Add 10 to 56 and you get 66. Now take 1 back: 66 minus 1 is 65. So 56 plus 9 is 65. And the same idea works for 99 — add 100, then take 1 back. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 47 plus 9? ... and what's 34 plus 99? ... Have a proper go before I tell you ... Let's check them together. 47 plus 9: add 10 to get 57, then take 1 back — 56. So 47 plus 9 is 56. Now 34 plus 99: add 100 to get 134, then take 1 back — 133. So 34 plus 99 is 133. A big scary 99 turned into two baby steps. That's it — you now know a trick most grown-ups don't.

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